The *Mahavamsa* further relates how a Buddhist missionary named Mahadhammarakkhita was sent to Maharattha (modern Maharashtra) where he converted eighty-four thousand persons; another elder, Mahadeva, was sent to Mahishamandala – probably the Mysore region; 'Dammarakkitha the Greek' was sent to Aparantanka ('the western ends') where he converted thirty-seven thousand; and Rakkhita was sent to Vanavasa ('forest country') where he converted sixty thousand and founded six hundred *vihara*s, or monasteries – this Vanavasa most probably being Banavasi in western Karnataka, which later became the capital of the Kadambas in the fourth century. The Buddhist traveller Xuanzang passed through this same Vanavasa region in about the year 642 and reported the existence of more than a hundred monasteries with over ten thousand monks. He also noted the presence of several hundred non-Buddhist temples where 'heretics of different faiths live together'. Modern Banavasi is now an important centre of Shaivism, dominated by the honey-coloured stones of the ninth-century Madhukeshvara temple, one of many Shaiva temples suspected of having originated as Buddhist shrines.

A later chapter of the 'Great Chronicle' describes how the Chola prince Elara (Ellalan) of Thiruvarur invaded and captured the throne of Lanka in about 205 BCE but was later killed in battle by the Sinhala prince Dutugamunu in about 161 BCE. The peace that followed allowed King Dutugamunu to complete the building of the giant stupa of Ruwanweliseya at Anuradhapura to house the Buddha's begging bowl, after which many thousands of Buddhist monks came from all over India to attend the ceremony, including 'the great *thera* [elder] Candagutta from the Vanavasa country together with eighty thousand ascetics'. Even if we knock off the usual two or three noughts, this list shows that Buddhism was well established in several regions of South India by the second century BCE.